

2. Heat 2 tablespoons of the butter in a medium nonstick skillet over medium heat. Sauté the shallots until fragrant and translucent, about 3 minutes; add the spinach and salt and pepper to taste and cook, stirring occasionally, until combined, about 2 minutes. Transfer to a medium bowl; set aside. Add the wine to the skillet, increase the heat to medium-high, and simmer until reduced to $\frac{1}{4}$ cup, 2 to 3 minutes; set aside.

3. Butter an 8-inch square baking dish with the remaining 1 tablespoon butter; arrange half of the bread slices buttered-side up in a single layer in the dish. Sprinkle half of the spinach mixture, then $\frac{1}{2}$ cup grated cheese evenly over the bread slices. Arrange the remaining bread slices in a single layer over the cheese; sprinkle the remaining spinach mixture and another $\frac{1}{2}$ cup cheese evenly over the bread. Whisk the eggs in a medium bowl until combined; whisk in the reduced wine, the half-and-half, 1 teaspoon salt, and pepper to taste. Pour the egg mixture evenly over the bread layers; cover the surface flush with plastic wrap, weight down (see note), and refrigerate at least 1 hour or up to overnight.

4. Remove the dish from the refrigerator and let stand at room temperature 20 minutes. Meanwhile, adjust an oven rack to the middle position and heat the oven to 325 degrees. Uncover the strata and sprinkle the remaining $\frac{1}{2}$ cup cheese evenly over the surface. Bake until both the edges and the center are puffed and the edges have pulled away slightly from the sides of the dish, 50 to 55 minutes (or about 60 minutes for a doubled recipe). Cool on a wire rack for 5 minutes; serve.

➤ VARIATION

Breakfast Strata with Sausage, Mushrooms, and Monterey Jack

- 8-10 ($\frac{1}{2}$ -inch-thick) slices supermarket French or Italian bread
- 3 tablespoons unsalted butter, softened
- 8 ounces bulk breakfast sausage, crumbled
- 3 medium shallots, minced
- 8 ounces white button mushrooms, wiped clean and quartered

Salt and ground black pepper

- $\frac{1}{2}$ cup medium-dry white wine, such as Sauvignon Blanc
- 6 ounces Monterey Jack cheese, shredded (about $1\frac{1}{2}$ cups)
- 6 large eggs
- $1\frac{3}{4}$ cups half-and-half
- 2 tablespoons minced fresh parsley leaves

Follow the recipe for Breakfast Strata with Spinach and Gruyère through step 1. Fry the sausage in a medium nonstick skillet over medium heat, breaking the sausage apart with a wooden spoon, until it loses its raw color and begins to brown, about 4 minutes; add the shallots and cook, stirring frequently, until softened and translucent, about 1 minute longer. Add the mushrooms and cook until they no longer release liquid, about 6 minutes; transfer to a medium bowl and season with salt and pepper to taste. Reduce the wine as directed in step 2; continue with the recipe from step 3, adding the parsley to the egg mixture along with the salt and pepper and substituting the sausage mixture for the spinach. (For a doubled recipe, increase the baking time to about 1 hour 20 minutes.)

FRENCH TOAST

FRENCH TOAST (OR IN FRENCH, *PAIN PERDU*, meaning "lost bread") started out as a simple way to use up old bread by dipping it in beaten egg and frying it. Many recipes today deviate little from this basic technique, calling for a couple of eggs and a touch of milk. What they produce, however, is a toast that tastes mostly of fried egg and that, depending on the amount of liquid, is either overly soggy or still dry in the middle.

We wanted something quite different: bread that was crisp and buttery on the outside, soft and custard-like on the inside. We sought a balance of flavors rather than just egg. Our ideal French toast had to be sweet enough to eat with only a sprinkling of confectioners' sugar, but not so sweet that we couldn't top it with syrup or fruit if we chose.

We started testing with a simple formula: 2 eggs beaten with $\frac{1}{2}$ cup milk to soak 4 slices of $\frac{3}{4}$ -inch-thick, day-old French bread. From this starting point, we wanted to settle first on which bread works best for French toast, but that proved to be the hardest part of the testing. At first, it seemed simple. One-inch-thick slices of any sort of bread were too thick; they either soaked up too much liquid and didn't cook through, or they stayed dry in the middle with shorter soaking. So we stuck with $\frac{3}{4}$ -inch-thick slices and tried different kinds of bread: baguettes, supermarket breads, challah and brioche, and a dense white bread.

At the end of these tests, we thought we had the answer. Challah was clearly best, adding a lot of flavor and richness, staying generally crisp outside and somewhat moist inside—not perfect but likely to improve with changes in the liquid component. Baguette slices and slices of a high-quality Italian bread, so long as they weren't more than a day old, came in second. Hard-to-find brioche was only acceptable. Brioche can vary widely in quality, and the open-textured version we were using failed to take up the liquid evenly. Dense white bread simply tasted like fried bread, so it rated near the bottom. Presliced sandwich bread was acceptable in a pinch, although just barely. Worst, though, was the supermarket bakery version of French or Italian bread. Spongy and flabby, this bread simply fell apart when we took it out of the liquid. For the moment, the bread issue seemed resolved. So, using challah for testing, we moved on to the liquids.

Because we didn't want our French toast to be too eggy, we first tried dropping the number of eggs in the test recipe from two to one. That decision showed an immediate improvement, yielding a finished product that was crispier outside but still soft inside. To be sure that fewer eggs made for a better result, we tried going the opposite way, using 3 eggs to $\frac{1}{2}$ cup milk. That confirmed it: More egg seemed to create a barrier on the outside of the bread, causing the interior to stay dry while the outside tasted like fried egg.

The next logical step seemed to be to increase the milk, given that a higher proportion of milk to egg had worked so far. A jump to 1 cup milk

made the bread too wet inside, but it was better than $\frac{1}{2}$ cup. Three quarters of a cup proved to be ideal, as the toast stayed custard-like inside and fairly crisp outside.

Throughout our tests with egg and milk, our basic recipe had tasted flat. We were looking forward to the final tests, when we would add other ingredients. We first tried salt, which gave the recipe a big boost: Just $\frac{1}{4}$ teaspoon and the toast finally had some flavor. We added sugar next, which also made a great difference. At this point, 1 tablespoon seemed like a good amount for toast that would be covered with syrup; after making the recipe adjustments described below, though, we found that 2 tablespoons proved best. Finally, we added vanilla. Few recipes call for it, but 2 teaspoons really balanced the flavors.

After all this, we had a French toast that was better than any we could remember, yet still not ideal. It was fairly crisp, but not exactly what we were after: an almost deep-fried crispness. We knew the sugar helped, but there had to be something else we could do. When one editor mentioned a French toast version she'd once had in which the bread was dipped in pancake batter, plus a recipe that called for a pinch of flour, it got us thinking about what flour could do. Ultimately, what it did was solve the puzzle.

At first we liked 1 tablespoon flour, which helped to further crisp the exterior and keep the toast from becoming greasy. In later tests, however, we noticed that this made the toast somewhat soggy inside; yet when we went up to 2 tablespoons, the bread became tough. So we started trying more flour—but with butter added to the batter to keep the bread from toughening. After a few more tests, we finally had fabulous French toast: A batter with $\frac{1}{2}$ cup flour balanced by 2 tablespoons melted butter turned the outside of the challah evenly crisp and brown and let just enough moisture through to the interior to keep it custard-like but not heavy.

Unfortunately, our perfect French toast recipe worked wonders with challah but failed with chewy French and Italian breads. While we strongly recommend using challah if you can, we know it's less likely to be the day-old bread

people have on hand. So we worked out a separate recipe for French and Italian breads, but we recommend it with a caveat: If you're using soft supermarket-style French bread or sliced white sandwich bread, go with the challah recipe. With a chewier, drier French or Italian loaf, however, the high amount of flour in the batter used for challah prevented needed moisture from soaking into the bread. Also, the exterior had a harder time crisping because the rougher surface of this somewhat open-textured bread didn't make good contact with the pan. To get more moisture to the interior, we tried dropping some of the flour; to better crisp the exterior, we again tried a two-egg recipe. Neither trick worked. In the end, more tests showed that the recipe needed even more milk for a custard-like interior and just 1 tablespoon of flour to aid in crisping; with this little flour, the batter needed no butter.

French Toast for Challah or Sandwich Bread

MAKES 4 TO 5 SLICES FROM CHALLAH OR 6 TO 8 SLICES FROM SANDWICH BREAD

Though thick-sliced challah is best for French toast, you can substitute high-quality, presliced sandwich bread. Flipping challah is easiest with tongs, but a spatula works best with sandwich bread. To speed the cooking of large quantities, heat 2 or more skillets to brown a few batches at once. To vary the flavor of the batter, add ¼ teaspoon ground cinnamon or ½ teaspoon ground nutmeg with the dry ingredients, or substitute almond extract for the vanilla.

- 1 large egg
- 2 tablespoons unsalted butter, melted
- ¾ cup milk
- 2 teaspoons vanilla extract
- 2 tablespoons sugar
- ⅓ cup unbleached all-purpose flour
- ¼ teaspoon salt
- 4-5 slices day-old challah, ¾ inch thick, or 6-8 slices day-old high-quality sandwich bread
- Unsalted butter for frying (1 tablespoon per batch)

1. Heat a 10- or 12-inch skillet (preferably cast iron) over medium heat for 5 minutes. Meanwhile, beat the egg lightly in a shallow pan or pie plate; whisk in the melted butter, then the milk and vanilla, and finally the sugar, flour, and salt, continuing to whisk until smooth. Soak the bread without oversaturating, about 40 seconds per side for challah or 30 seconds per side for sandwich bread. Pick up the bread and allow the excess batter to drip off; repeat with the remaining slices.

2. Swirl 1 tablespoon butter in the hot skillet. Transfer the prepared bread to the skillet in a single layer; cook until golden brown, about 1 minute 45 seconds on the first side and 1 minute on the second. Serve the French toast immediately. Continue, adding 1 tablespoon butter to the skillet for each new batch.

French Toast for Firm European-Style Bread

MAKES 4 TO 8 SLICES,
DEPENDING ON THE LOAF

This recipe has less flour than the version above, which allows the batter to penetrate more easily into drier, chewier French or Italian loaves.

- 1 large egg
- 1 cup milk
- 2 teaspoons vanilla extract
- 2 tablespoons sugar
- 1 tablespoon unbleached all-purpose flour
- ¼ teaspoon salt
- 4-8 slices firm, day-old European-style bread, such as French or Italian, ¾ inch thick
- Unsalted butter for frying (1 tablespoon per batch)

1. Heat a 10- or 12-inch skillet (preferably cast iron) over medium heat for 5 minutes. Meanwhile, beat the egg lightly in a shallow pan or pie plate; whisk in the milk and vanilla, and then the sugar, flour, and salt, continuing to whisk until smooth. Soak the bread without oversaturating, about 30 seconds per side. Pick up the bread and allow the excess batter to drip off; repeat with the remaining slices.